dimension of the hijack, we also need to see the positive dimension'.[171] The safe return of the plane and all hostages was the positive in Akbar Agha's words. 'All the people were rescued … it was great and positive work that the Taliban did'. Also, 'the Taliban has an independent viewpoint, regardless of what Pakistan says,' he added.[172] Hakim Mujahid, the Taliban's representative to the UN in 2001, corroborates this point. There was no diplomatic relationship between the Indian government and the Taliban. 'And the Indian government also made the mistake of not recognising that [Taliban] government at that time … and I do remember that the Taliban authorities very wisely dealt with that [IC-814] case and they could release safely the Indian airplane. That was also a point of making good relations between the Indian government and the Taliban authorities. But both India and the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan could not exploit that opportunity (sic)'.[173] Instead, on 19 December 2000, India co-sponsored (with the US and Russia) UNSC Resolution 1333,[174] that banned all military assistance to the Taliban and ordered a closure of its various training camps.[175]

When asked what the Taliban conveyed to Pakistan during the hijack, Mujahid was categorical: 'that it will be good for the Pakistani authorities to not allow the plane to come to Afghanistan. Not to use Afghanistan's soil for this kind of incidents'.[176] Reports from the *Afghan Islamic Press*, an online news bulletin used by the Taliban to advocate its views, confirm that the Taliban wanted the plane to leave Afghan soil immediately.[177] Once it was established that the plane was not in the condition to fly due to technical faults, the hijackers were asked to surrender or release the hostages. Though Indian officials remained unconvinced, this narrative does hold currency. Dulat confirms that the message India was getting from the Taliban during the hijacking was 'we [Taliban] don't know you [India] guys, you don't want to know us'.[178] This was one reason why Jaswant Singh, whatever the intent and consequences of his visit to Kandahar may have been, 'was totally out of his own when he landed in Kandahar'. For Dulat, a long-time conciliator, the IC-814 experience should have taught India a lesson, which was to talk to everyone, because once a state decides on blanket engagement, no actor gets too comfortable.[179] Expecting the Taliban to be sensitive towards India after rejecting the regime (in addition to Pakistan's